

> **"THOSE WHO DID BHAKTI OF LORD RAM GRADUALLY BECAME ARROGANT. THAT PARTY WAS DECLARED THE BIGGEST PARTY, BUT WAS STOPPED AT 240 BY LORD RAM DUE TO ARROGANCE"**
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> **INDIRESH KUMAR,** *Senior pracharak and National Executive Member, RSS, in a remark he later sought to 'amend'*

or stated antipathy towards the RSS. What they found galling was how some of them even got crucial organisational responsibilities. A top RSS leader explains that the Sangh is not insensitive to the political party's tactical need for inorganic growth, but that does not quell the misgivings when moves on the political chessboard are too aberrational. "Being in government is one way of executing ideological commitments. But one should be aware of the price," he says.

And even affiliates can line up to insist on a fair price. On June 21, the student wing ABVP joined the Opposition's protests against the National Testing Agency (NTA) in Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Odisha and Maharashtra. Cities such as Bhopal, Hyderabad, Itanagar, Kanpur and Jhansi saw ABVP activists take to the streets and burn effigies—the student body's first direct protest against the Centre in the past decade. What lends it extra significance is the fact that the ABVP is seen as steered by RSS officials closely aligned with the BJP. The cue has gone out to other affiliates—the labour union Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh (BMS), the farmers' body Bharatiya Kisan Sangh (BKS) and the Swadeshi Jagran Manch (SJM)—that had been consigned to near-oblivion when it came to policy-making. The signalling is working. On June 20, Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman engaged in pre-budget consultations with a panel that included SJM national co-convenor Ashwani Mahajan. And on July 4, she conferred with all RSS affiliates active in the economic sphere: SJM, BKS, BMS, Laghu Udyog Bharati, Grahak Panchayat etc.

Allowing one's own on the debating table is an effective political strategy that goes beyond courtesy, point out RSS insiders. In Modi 1.0 and even the first year of Modi 2.0, RSS affiliates had frequently occupied the oppositional space—that ideational plurality helped the BJP regime fine-tune and refine its policies, even make tactical retreats, as with the land acquisition ordinances, the labour codes or the "poorly negotiated" RCEP (Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership). In the end, it prevents too much space being ceded to the Opposition. But disquiet had been growing over the contempt shown during Modi 2.0 for its affiliates' views on policy, especially in the post-Covid phase. The absence of 'many voices' stung during the aggressive push for farm sector reforms—a Minimum Support Price (MSP) is among the issues where the BKS-SJM differ with the Centre, as also on GM crops.

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PANGS OF POWER

Umbilically linked though they are, history has seen both structural and personality-based issues cropping up between the BJP-RSS during encounters with power. The present strain in ties, in fact, is nothing close to what was witnessed during and after the first NDA government, between then sarsanghchalak K.S. Sudarshan and Atal Bihari Vajpayee and, later, even L.K. Advani. RSS pracharaks like Dattopant Thengadi (then the patron of BMS, BKS and SJM) and Vishwa Hindu Parishad leader Giriraj Kishore—rather than Opposition leaders—proved to be among the harshest critics of the BJP then. Invariably, the disputation owed to misalignment between the political growth gene and the ideological one. And the present passage has seen a decade of near-superpower status for the BJP within India's polity, so a touch of evolutionary pain was inevitable. It hardly leaves the RSS untouched—many top pracharaks were seen shedding their monastic vows of renunciation, so to speak, to turn themselves into full-time politicians. The considered opinion is that Bhagwat leans towards ideological purity while there are others in the Sangh hierarchy more in sync with a political vision.

Like with policy, political strategy too profits from accommodation. Leaders of RSS affiliates, for one, had worked with N. Chandrababu Naidu to convince the BJP leadership of the need for a pre-poll alliance in Andhra Pradesh. The Sangh's eyes were set, inter alia, on religious conversions, but with Kerala, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal and Punjab looming as remaining frontiers, it works to mutual advantage. The enabling factor is that, in Modi, the RSS still sees a rare convergence of ideology and political viability. So, the voicing of displeasure is perhaps not more than chastisement from a doting teacher to a favourite pupil. An insider called it a "lover's tiff"—and nothing solves that like good conversations. ■